

James Symons-Hicks

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EDUCATION

PhD Economics

2026 – Present

University of California, Berkeley, USA

Teaching: Reader, ECON 136: Financial Economics, Fall 2026.

MSc Economics

2023 – 2024

University College London (UCL), UK

Grade: *Distinction*

Named on Dean's List, Faculty of Social and Historical Sciences.

Thesis: “A Q-Learning Approach to Algorithmic Market Making for Risky Securities”

BSc Economics

2020 – 2023

University College London (UCL), UK

Grade: *First Class Honours*

Thesis: “Unravelling the Influence of Retail Investors on Liquidity and Volatility in UK Markets”

RESEARCH POSITIONS

Pre-Doctoral Research Assistant

Sept 2024 – Aug 2026

Profs. Matthias Doepke & Ethan Ilzetzki, London School of Economics

London, UK

- Assisted in research on “Family Macroeconomics” (Doepke) and “Fiscal Policy, Productivity & Growth” (Ilzetzki).

Research Assistant

May 2022 – Sept 2024

Prof. Antonio Guarino, University College London

London, UK

- Assisted in research on financial decision-making, social learning, and experimental economics.

RESEARCH PAPERS

Publications

“The Influence of Market Dynamics on Retail Investor Attention” [[Paper](#)]

UCL Journal of Economics 2(1), 36–64, 2023.

Working Papers

“This Time It’s Different: The Role of Women’s Employment in Recessions” [[Paper](#)]

with T. Alon (UCSD), M. Doepke (LSE), J. Olmstead-Rumsey (LSE), and M. Tertilt (Mannheim).

“From Learning to Earning: Financial Literacy and Wealth Accumulation in the UK” [[Paper](#)]

Presented at LSE Pre-Doctoral Work-in-Progress Seminar (May & November 2025).

“Q-Learning and Algorithmic Market Making: Loss-free, Collusive, or Competitive Prices?” [[Paper](#)]

with A. Guarino (UCL) and P. Jehiel (UCL, PSE).

R&R, Review of Financial Studies. CEPR Discussion Paper No. 20461, 2025.

PROFESSIONAL ACTIVITIES

Referee: *Review of Economic Studies*, *Journal of Monetary Economics*, *UCL Journal of Economics*

Scientific Committee: UCL Explore Econ Conference Jun 2023

Outreach: Presenter & Panel Member, Discover Economics Project Jun 2023

WORKSHOPS AND TRAINING

Tools for Macroeconomists Summer School [\[Link\]](#) Aug 2025

SICSS–ODIESSI (Summer Institute in Computational Social Science) [\[Link\]](#) Jul 2025

Workshop on Demand System Asset Pricing [\[Link\]](#) May 2025

ADDITIONAL INFORMATION

Languages: English (Native), Spanish (Advanced)

Programming: *Proficient* — Stata, MATLAB, Python, R, $\text{\LaTeX}$; *Familiar* — Dynare, Mathematica

Other: LTA Level 2 Tennis Coach